

Module 7: ASPECTS OF GRAMMAR

THE PHRASE/GROUP

A phrase is a group of words without a subject or a predicate, but functions as a component of a sentence. In English, phrases may be categorized according to use, such as noun phrase, verb phrase, adverb phrase, and adjective phrase.

Examples:

1. **The beautiful garden** (noun phrase)
2. **In the morning** (prepositional phrase)
3. **Very quickly** (adverbial phrase)

Types of Phrases

1. **Noun Phrase (NP)** – the noun phrase is a group of words in which the head word is a noun or pronoun.

The structure of a noun phrase is MHQ, wherein M- modifier, H – head, and Q- qualifier.

The modifier (m) that precedes the headword (h) is called a pre-modifier. The headword (H) is the obligatory element in the group of words. The qualifier (q) is another element after the headword; it is known as a post-modifier.

Example: The great physician.

(m) (m) (h)

The great physician of our time

(m) (m) (h) (q) (q) (q)

Modifiers preceding the headwords can be :

1. Determinants: such articles – *a, the*, etc; personal pronouns – *my, their*, etc; demonstratives – *this, those*, etc, and possessive nouns – *Yinka's, John's*, etc.
2. Epithet – adjectives – *big, great, beautiful*, etc.
3. Nominator (when they pre-modify other nouns) – *African, Nigerian*, etc.

1. NP as subject of a sentence

Example: **The dark-complexioned, beautiful physician** is here

2. NP as complement of a sentence

Example: My wife is **a beautiful woman**

3. NP as object of complement

Example: The head teacher called the student **a responsible boy**

4. NP as complement of a preposition

Example: The Chief Medical Director hid the medical records in **his lockable drawer**

2. **Adjective Phrase (AdjP)** – describes a noun.

Example: The bag **on the table** is mine.

The girl **in the red dress** is beautiful

3. **Adverbial Phrase (AdvP)** – modifies a verb, adjective, or adverb.

Example:

We chatted **passionately**

I saw him **late in the evening**

4. **Prepositional Phrase (PP)** – begins with a preposition.

Example: The cat hid **under the bed**.

5. **Verb Phrase (VP)** – made up of a main verb and auxiliary verb(s).

Example: She **has been working** since morning.

The food **is being served**

THE CLAUSE

A clause is a grammatical unit or group of words that has a finite verb and can convey meaning. A clause is named according to its function. It can function as a noun, adjective, and adverb. A clause can be main/independent or subordinate/dependent as explain below.

Classification of Clauses

Clauses can be classified along two divisions. They are as follows:

- Main or Independent Clause: capable of standing on its own and conveying complete meaning.

Example: The referee blew the whistle and the football match began.

Each clause can be written as a sentence and it will express a complete thought e.g.

1. The referee blew the whistle
2. The football match began

- Subordinate or Dependent Clause cannot stand alone in a sentence, but derives its meaning from the main clause because it depends on it to convey meaning. In English, each subordinate clause can be used as a part of speech and performs the functions of an adjective, adverb and a noun as the case may be.

TYPES OF CLAUSES

There are different types of clauses as discussed below:

Noun Clause

Noun clauses perform the same functions as nouns in a sentence. As with nouns, the noun clause performs any of the following functions:

Functions of a Noun Clause

- ⊙ **Subject of a Verb:** In sentence initial position, it functions as the subject of the verb that follows it. When it functions as the **subject of a verb**, it basically tells **what the sentence is about**. Clauses starting with **what, whether, that, why**, and **how** these often turn into subjects in sentences.

Examples:

1. What she said surprised everyone.
2. *Whether we win or lose* doesn't matter.
3. *That he missed the bus* annoyed his teacher
4. *Why she left early* is still unknown.
5. *How they solved the problem* amazed the whole class.
6. *Where she hid the money* remains a mystery.
7. *That he became the president* surprised many politicians.

- ⊙ **Object of a Verb:** when it directly or indirectly receives an action set in motion by the subject. In most cases, a noun clause function as the object, thereby completing the verb and answering the question *what* asked after the verb. Common verbs that take noun clauses as objects include: **know, believe, think, hope, ask, explain, realize, wonder, tell**, and **admit**.

Examples:

1. Can you explain *how the machine works*?
2. He doesn't understand *why she left early*.
3. We believe *that the plan will succeed*.
4. She told me *where she was going*.
5. I know *that she is telling the truth*.

- ◎ **Subject Complement:** when it comes after a linking verb (*is, are, was, were, seems, becomes etc.*), referring to the same entity as the subject or explains the subject.

Examples:

1. My belief is *that honesty is the best policy*.
2. The problem is *what we should focus on first*.
3. Her suggestion was *that we meet earlier*.
4. The question is *whether we can finish on time*.
5. The truth is *that he never lied to anyone*.

- ◎ **Object Complement** when it follows the direct object and renames it or refers to the same entity as that object. It explains, or completes the meaning of the direct object.

Examples:

1. They elected him *what he truly is: a leader of integrity*.
2. We made the teacher *who she is today*.

ADJECTIVAL/RELATIVE CLAUSE

An adjectival/relative clause is a subordinate clause that functions as an adjective, it qualifies a noun or a pronoun. It is also called a relative clause because it is usually introduced by relative pronouns such as *who, whose, that, which* and *whom*.

Examples:

1. The students **who studied hard** succeeded.
2. My sister **who gave me this pen** travelled to London.
3. The students, **whose guardians attended the meeting**, will be admitted.
4. The place, **where the man was buried** is not known.
5. The matter **that we discussed last night** is still fresh in my memory.

It should be noted that some of the relative pronouns that introduce the adjectival clause may sometimes be omitted.

Examples:

- The place, **the man was buried**, is not known. ('Where' has been omitted).

- The matter **we discussed last night** is still fresh in my memory. ('That' has been omitted).

ADVERBIAL CLAUSE

An adverbial clause is a dependent (subordinate) clause that functions as an adverb in a sentence. It modifies a verb, an adjective, or another adverb by giving more information about the main clause.

Adverbial structures answer certain questions and are, therefore, named after the questions they answer.

- ⊙ **Adverbial Clauses of Time** answer the question “when?”
- ⊙ **Adverbial Clauses of Place** answer the question “where?”
- ⊙ **Adverbial Clauses of Manner** answer the question “how?”
- ⊙ **Adverbial Clauses of Reason** answer the question “why?”
- ⊙ **Adverbial Clause of Condition** stipulates conditions
- ⊙ **Adverbial Clause of Concession** answers the question “?”
- ⊙ **Adverbial Clause of Result** answers the question “?”

Examples::

- ⊙ **Time:** I will call you **when I arrive home**.
- ⊙ **Reason/Cause:** She stayed at home **because she was sick**.
- ⊙ **Condition:** You can join us **if you finish your work**.
- ⊙ **Contrast/Concession:** **Although it was raining**, we went for a walk.
- ⊙ **Purpose:** He whispered **so that no one could hear him**.
- ⊙ **Place:** I'll meet you **where the two roads cross**.
- ⊙ **Manner:** Do it **as I showed you**.

THE SENTENCE

A sentence is a grammatically complete unit, consisting of a group of related words that expresses a complete, meaningful thought. Sentences can be classified by structure and by function.

Sentences by Structure are classified according to the type of clauses they contain.

1. **A simple sentence** consists of one main clause that expresses a complete thought, consisting of a finite verb and its subject.

Example: 1. She drives the car.

2. The sun rose slowly.
3. My sister sings beautifully.
4. The children laughed.
5. That idea makes sense.
6. Birds migrate in winter.

2. **A compound sentence** contains two or more main clause linked together by coordinating conjunctions.

Example: 1. The convocation programme went smoothly and the Vice Chancellor

commended the diligent staff

2. The sky cleared, and the birds began to sing.
4. She cooked dinner and he washed the dishes.
5. The team practiced hard yet they lost the match.
6. You can take the bus or you can walk.

3. **A complex sentence** contains one main clause and one or more subordinate clauses

Example: 1. I left early because the storm was getting worse.

2. When the bell rang, the students rushed out.
3. She smiled although she was exhausted.
4. They stayed home since the roads were closed.
5. The movie ended after the lights came on.

4. **A compound-complex** sentence is a combination of compound and complex sentences. Therefore, it has two or more main clauses and one or more subordinate clauses.

Example: 1. I finished my project, but I was tired because I worked all night.

2. When the rain stopped, we went outside, and we played soccer.

3. She stayed home because she felt sick, but she still finished her work.

4. The teacher smiled after the presentation ended, and the students cheered.

5. Although he was nervous, he gave the speech, and everyone applauded.

Sentences can be classified by the functions they perform.

1. **A declarative sentence** gives a piece of information in a statement form and ends with a full stop.

Example: 1. I declare you husband and wife
2. The meeting starts at noon.
3. We're planning a trip next month.
4. Your suggestion seems reasonable.
5. This room feels very cold.
6. The results were better than expected.

2. **An interrogative sentence** is a question or request that ends with a question mark.

Example: 1. What time is the meeting?
2. Are you coming with us?
3. Why did they cancel the event?
4. Did you finish the assignment?
5. Where are we supposed to go?

Note: Interrogative sentences could be in three forms:

A. Wh- Questions

1. Where did you put the keys?
2. Why is the meeting starting late?

B. Polar (Yes/No) Questions

1. Did you finish the report?
2. Is she coming to the conference?

C. Tag Questions

1. You know the answer, don't you?
2. They arrived early, didn't they?

3. **An imperative sentence** is a statement that gives command, request or directives.

Example: 1. Close the door.
2. Please hand me the report.
3. Turn left at the next corner.
4. Don't touch that wire.
5. Help me with this box.

4. **An exclamatory sentence** expresses feelings, opinion, or fact in an emphatic way. It ends with exclamation mark.

Example: 1. What a beautiful day!
2. How quickly the time flies!
3. What an incredible performance!
4. How bright that star is!
5. What a mess this place is!

